Stephen Dossou

Mines Paris – PSL, CERNA
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Citizenship: Benin

Research Fields

Primary: Entrepreneurial Finance, Venture Capital
Secondary: Contract Theory and Mechanism Design, Applied Econometrics

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, Mines Paris – PSL (CERNA, ED SDOSE) 2024 – expected 2027
Advisors: Pierre Fleckinger and Philippe Mustar

Diplôme d'Ingénieur (M.Sc. equivalent), CentraleSupélec 2020 – 2024
Information & Communication Engineering. Optimization, machine learning, network theory, quantitative modelling.

Classes Préparatoires (MPSI, MP*), Lycée Louis-le-Grand, Paris 2018 – 2020
Competitive undergraduate programme in advanced mathematics and physics.

Visiting Positions

Visiting Ph.D. Student, Imperial College Business School, London Oct. – Nov. 2026
Host: Ramana Nanda (scheduled).

Honors and Awards

Ranked 1st nationwide, *Baccalauréat* série C (science track), Benin 2017

Ranked 1st nationwide, *BEPC* (lower-secondary national examination), Benin 2014

Job Market Paper

"Dilution Rules and the Value of a Most-Favored-Nation Clause"

I ask what a most-favored-nation (MFN) clause held by an accelerator is worth to the startups that grant it, as in the $375,000 uncapped MFN SAFE that Y Combinator added to its standard deal in 2022. In my model, the accelerator and a seed investor with market power finance an experiment, and competitive Series A investors finance its scaling. The value of the clause depends on the dilution rules of the seed contract. A firm without a seed round loses, because the MFN SAFE replaces Series A money that diluted the accelerator. With a seed equity round, the clause takes part of the seed investor's claims, and the firms whose need comes close to their value lose their seed round. With a capped seed SAFE, the seed investor invests more, and only the firms whose threshold is set by the SAFE's discount lose. All the losses come from the claim: the same cash without the clause harms no firm. *JEL:* G24, G23, D82, D86.

WORKING PAPERS

"Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions" (with Pierre Fleckinger)

- Venture capital contracts are bargained deal by deal with entrepreneurs, but contracts between institutions are not: an accelerator committing to a venture capitalist, or a venture capitalist committing to a limited partner, faces non-negotiable terms and often commits blind. In an informed-principal framework, when the principal reveals the project's expected outcome *after* the investor has committed — the LP-to-VC relationship — an optimal pooling mechanism exists and the budget constraint is slack in cash-rich economies, so every profitable project is financed. When revelation comes *before* the commitment — the accelerator-to-VC relationship — the unique optimal mechanism is again pooling, but the budget constraint binds in every economy and some positive-NPV projects are necessarily excluded. The observed uniformity of institutional terms is therefore an equilibrium object rather than an administrative convenience. *JEL:* G24, G23, D82, D86.

"Avoiding the British: Brexit and Partner Choice in European Venture Capital"

- Nothing in the UK's withdrawal restricted co-investment, yet continental venture capitalists whose pre-determined reliance on British partners was above the median cut the share of their syndicates including a British investor by 8.2 percentage points against a base rate of 18.7% ($p < 0.001$), from the semester of the referendum onwards. The effect is confined to the relational margin: deal counts, stages, round sizes, follow-on financing and exits are all null, established British ties dissolve no faster than comparable continental ones (triple difference $+0.3$ pp, $p = 0.77$), and aggregate UK–continental volume tracks the rest of Europe. Exposure-based event study on Crunchbase, wild-cluster bootstrap inference.

POLICY REPORTS

"Devenir ETI : les chemins de la croissance" June 2025
with Pierre Fleckinger, Philippe Mustar and Antoine Prévet.
Chaire etilab, Mines Paris – PSL. Report on the growth of French SMEs into mid-sized firms, based on statistical analysis of INSEE's FARE firm-level accounting files, accessed through the CASD.

PRESENTATIONS

EARIE (European Association for Research in Industrial Economics), Mannheim August 2026
Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions

Internal doctoral workshop, Mines Paris – PSL (CERNA) July 2026
Avoiding the British: Brexit and Partner Choice in European Venture Capital

IOEA (Institute of Organizational Economics Academy), Cargèse April 2026
Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions

Journée des Doctorants (joint with Université Paris-Dauphine), Mines Paris – PSL March 2026
Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions

TEACHING

Microeconomics (undergraduate, first-year engineering cycle) 2024 – 2026
Teaching assistant (*travaux dirigés*), Mines Paris – PSL. Two academic years (2024–2025, 2025–2026); 6 hours of tutorials per year plus exam grading.

Professional Experience

Research Assistant, Mines Paris – PSL Jan. 2024 – Oct. 2024
Research on startups and mid-sized firms in France; construction and analysis of large firm-level financial datasets.

Business Analyst (apprenticeship), Forvia Sept. 2022 – Jan. 2024
Digital transformation initiatives in an industrial environment; operational monitoring tools.

Marketing Analyst (internship), Manda Sept. 2021 – Jan. 2022
Acquisition strategy and performance analytics.

Data Scientist (internship), Onogone July – Aug. 2021
Development and evaluation of NLP models.

Skills

Methods: Panel and event-study designs, difference-in-differences and triple differences, wild-cluster bootstrap inference with few clusters, falsification and placebo protocols, mechanism design and optimal control.

Software: Python, R, LaTeX, Matlab.

Data: Crunchbase; construction of investor–round and dyad-level panels (>1.2M investor–round observations). Security clearance for confidential statistical data (*habilitation au secret statistique*) and accredited user of the CASD (*Centre d'accès sécurisé aux données*); work on INSEE's FARE firm-level accounting files.

Languages

French (native), English (C1).

References

Pierre Fleckinger
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Philippe Mustar
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